How Do You Lead Professionals? 'Setting The Score For A Band Of Cats'

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'I am a friend and I am not a slave - I am the cat who walks by himself.' Rudyard Kipling (1902)

'To gain the friendship of a cat is a difficult thing. The cat is a philosophical, methodical, quiet animal, tenacious of its own habits, fond of order and cleanliness and does not confer its friendship easily. If you are worthy of its affection a cat will be your friend, but never your slave.' Theophile Gautier, French poet (1811)

1 Introduction

How do you create the 'climate', the culture or environment in the firm such that people are aligned behind, and motivated by, the achievement of your strategic objectives. In a word how do you provide **leadership?**

Leadership, is, we believe, vital for a practice, especially in these times of change for both business and the professions. Our experience, as professionals, and as managers / leaders of professionals, suggests, as does much recent theory, that many traditional images of leadership don't fit the needs of the professional service firm. We mix two images to relate leadership to our experience of reality; the highly individual and independent cat and the conductor whose task it is to produce both order and inspiration by melding the creative talents of individuals into a harmonious whole.

This paper has four main parts. The first introduces leadership and explores its role in improving the management and delivery of professional services in the late 1990s and beyond. The second summarises a number of models of leadership, drawn from extensive literature on the subject. The third develops the cat metaphor and considers some of the options available to a leader who wishes to influence the behaviour of an individual or a group. The last section then delves into the art and science of leading others, offering a music sheet of tips and tools for those who wish to develop their 'conducting' skills and style.

Note that we are concerned here with the leadership of professionals rather than 'professional leadership'. In many a traditional firm, or professional function in a larger organisation, the 'leader's role' as a manager or managing partner was often to be the supreme arbiter of professional standards. The Managing / Senior Partner was there to ensure standards were maintained. Reports and studies were examined and rejected if they were not up to scratch [or to an individuals judgement of 'scratch']. In industrial terms the role had a large component of 'quality control', inspection and rework built into it. Whilst that pattern may persist in many smaller practices, where a partner or senior professional checks what is done before it is released this paper is not concerned with control of professional standards but with leadership of people who happen to be professionals.

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2. Leadership and Professionals

2.1 What is leadership?

The problem with American business today is that people are administered not led. Most people in organisations have become, "but mortals conditioned to serve immortal institutions". Robert Townsend 1970 - Up The Organisation

Few people agree on what leadership ***is***. Most would say that they recognise it when they see it and all too often, when they do not. Leadership is often characterised as a powerful force which causes things to happen; a force that tends to be exercised by a charismatic individual. Popular images suggest that leadership is about being in charge, that it involves direction-setting and that followers are moved to action through the exercise of leadership. There is also much debate about the ways in which leadership is practised, in terms of behaviour and style as well as purpose and values.

Some common themes emerge from these pictures; for example:

- Leadership is a ***role*** or ***function*** that is carried out by an individual or a group
- It involves taking ***responsibility***, for the direction of the business or for the achievement of other goals.
- It is also about engaging others in working towards some common outcome, and setting an example of how this might be done, in formal or informal settings.

Another important message is that people have a variety of expectations of what leadership is and what leaders should do. The expectations of 'the led' can constrain and shape the task of leading just as much as can the particular requirements of the job or the skills and personality of an individual leader. Leadership then, is, among other things, creating or influencing the perceptions and expectations of others in the practice. If marketing involves creating perceptual patterns of thinking in the minds of potential clients, patterns that influence their actions; then leadership is concerned with a similar influencing process on the minds of those in the firm. In the process the leading is itself shaped by the perceptions carried in the minds of the followers. Leadership is a two-way process.

Some years ago a leading Japanese industrialist M. Konosuke Matshita, Executive Director of the Matsushita Electric Industrial Corporation, issued his often quoted but rarely acted on 'Challenge to the West';

We are going to win and the industrial West is going to lose. There is nothing much you can do about it, because the reasons for your failure are within yourselves. Your firms are built upon the Taylor model; even worse, so are your heads. With your bosses doing the thinking while the workers wield the screwdrivers, you're convinced deep down that this is the right way to run a business. For you, the essence of management is getting the ideas out of the heads of the bosses in to the hands of labour.

We are beyond the Taylor model: business, we know, is now so complex and difficult, the survival of the firms so hazardous in an environment increasingly unpredictable, competitive and fraught with danger, that their continued existence depends upon the day-to-day mobilisation of every ounce of intelligence. For us, the core of management is precisely the art of mobilising and pulling together the intellectual resources of all employees in the service of the firm. Only by drawing on the combined brainpower of all its employees can a firm face up to the turbulence and constraints of today's environment.

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His point is that we have inherited a way of thinking about management that, whether articulated or not, shapes our behaviours as managers and the behaviours of others being managed. The role of the leader in the professional services firm was, perhaps, never so extreme an example of this 'managerial' tradition as it was in say manufacturing management. In the future it is likely to be even less so. **Only by drawing on and mobilising the combined brain power of all its employees, professional and non-professional will the practice of tomorrow survive and thrive**. One of the considerable advantages of the smaller firm is that such mobilisation is easier.

2.2 Why is leadership important?

Fundamentally, leadership is important because many people believe it to be. They believe it makes a significant difference to the direction of their lives or their work. More prosaically, when professional environments are in a state of flux in so many ways; the winners of the future are likely to be those who mobilise new groups of professionals to compete in new ways. Changing expectations of professional services and of professional-client relationships are in turn promoting changes in the way in which services are delivered and the way practice is organised (whether in private partnerships or public companies). And when put together, changes in these areas are challenging traditional concepts of professionalism and notions of professional competence.

Above all in times of change and uncertainty people are more likely to look for, respond to and indeed to need leadership. Management may work in a period of stability. Leadership is needed for the creation of a different future.

2.3 Leadership and Change

Many authors of management texts have highlighted the relationship between leadership and change. Some argue that change creates instability and uncertainty as well as opportunity. It demands adaptation in individual roles and attitudes as well as in organisational structures and cultures. The consequent turbulence creates both a psychological and a practical need for leadership. Others suggest that real leaders themselves initiate change, whether as a result of their own psychological makeup or as a result of the social and cultural expectations surrounding leadership. Change and leadership are like the chicken and the egg; change creates a need for leaders who in turn initiate more change.

The association helps explain the current calls for stronger leadership in professional service organisations. It also demonstrates a major purpose of leadership, to effect changes in structure and culture which will enable the organisation to survive and develop. The association also highlights other roles for the leader[s], roles that include:

- Interpreting the organisational mission in relation to the external environment [strategic thinking].
- Shaping, and where necessary, challenging the firm's reputation and tradition; providing vision and direction for the organisation.
- Creating, where necessary, new organisational frameworks and structures, roles and opportunities.
- Taking and assessing risk to the organisation and attempting to position it in the marketplace, and
- Aligning people with a new direction through consultation, communication, coalition-building and networking; representing the organisation, legally, politically and symbolically, and arbitrating between conflicting priorities (Middlehurst, 1993).

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2.4 How does leadership differ from management ?

OK. How does it?

There is probably no hard and fast answer, but management is more concerned with keeping things functioning smoothly in today's world. Leadership is concerned with moving into tomorrows. Why is it different for professionals?

2.5 Why is the process of leadership different in a professional service firm?

Understanding the difference means recognising first, the nature of being a professional and second, the structure and ownership patterns traditionally associated with 'the professions'.

(a) The Nature of Professional Work

The terms 'professional' and 'professional work' are composites which include the implication of the mastery of a particular body of knowledge, and representation through a professional body. In addition to expertise and knowledge they imply a range of common values, attitudes and behaviours. In summary:

- technical and theoretical ***expertise and the authority*** and status flowing from expert, and highly valued knowledge, understanding and skill,
- the establishment and the ***exercise of trust*** as a basis for professional relationships (with clients and between professionals),
- adherence to particular ***standards*** and professional ***ethics*** often, but not always, represented by the granting of a licence to practise,
- independence, ***autonomy*** and discretion, and
- specific attitudes towards work, clients and peers involving reliability, flexibility and creativity in relation to the 'unknown'.

Many aspects, and some would say traditional strengths, of professionalism are impacted by the changing world. They include the value and status to be placed on professional knowledge and competence; the balance between implicit trust and explicit accountability between professionals and clients; the appropriate standards governing professional practice and relationships; the degree of independence and autonomy of professionals; and the means of developing and maintaining appropriate professional attitudes and behaviours.

From the perspective of the leadership of a group of professionals the characteristics highlighted above have a number of consequences. First, they demand that the exercise of authority will need to flow through a process of influence and negotiation rather than by reliance on more direct position based power. Second, the often highly individualistic

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nature of professional work can tend to produce stronger external relationships with clients than with fellow professionals. Building horizontal communication links between apparently independent cells of professionals then becomes a key leadership function in professional service firms. Otherwise, the high levels of autonomy which exist in order to deliver effective service to the external client can work against the building of a strong sense of shared commitment between fellow professionals.

(*b*) *The Nature of Professional Service Firms*

The traditional professional service firm differs in a number of ways from other forms of organisation. First, and most strikingly, ownership, management and service delivery systems all reside with the same individuals (Howard, 1990). The inevitable leadership challenge exists when the personal interests of the owners do not coincide with those charged with management decision making. Second, the 'management hierarchy' of such an organisation, if it is recognised, is very flat.

Leadership in organisations of professionals must therefore take into account the particular structural features of these kinds of organisation as well as their present context and circumstances, the characteristics of the relevant practitioners and the expectations of major stakeholders / clients. In essence, leadership is likely to be a political and intellectually complex activity. Without thinking about it perhaps, the successful leader will be involved not only in providing direction but also in such interpersonal processes as:

Interpreting - understanding the real meanings behind peoples words and clarifying that others understand them.

Negotiating - building often unwritten and implicit agreements between individuals.

Networking - creating formal and informal links within the firm and in the wider business world,

'Framing' - influencing the frames of reference with which individuals make judgements of situations[1], and

Signalling[2] - challenging, guiding and wielding influence.

All are part of the process of creating an appropriate environment and climate for professional work. The harder structural aspects of the organisation play a part but so too do the softer aspects of values, purpose, meaning and culture. The leader must learn to align them appropriately.

Another way of summing it up is making *it* happen, deciding and articulating what *'it'* is, and taking people with you individually and corporately. ***How?***

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[1] As an example of 'framing' or 'reframing' consider the classic Mark Twain story of Tom Sawyer assigned to paint a fence. By having friends believe how rare an opportunity it was for a boy to paint a fence he has them queuing up to pay for the privilege of helping.

[2] Dramatic signals can be an effective way of indicating a change in an organisation. On possibly apocryphal story exists of a new CEO who triggered a revival of the companies fortunes by having the old corporate headquarters [the founders original] dynamited. A video of the event was sent to all employees, apparently three years of record results followed!

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3. Views of Leadership

The oldest known works on leadership come from the Chinese scholar Lao Tze who wrote 3,000 years ago:

'Some leaders the people fear, others the people admire, the best they do not notice, when the best leaders work is done the people say "we did it ourselves' ;

He remains one of the most frequently repeated theorists of all time. Since then, many historians, military tacticians and political theorists have joined the fray. In the twentieth century, leadership has become a subject for academic research, mainly in the fields of psychology, politics and organisational behaviour. Approaches to the subject have developed into different schools of thought, each of which has provided useful insights for practical application. Some of the more common models which have developed are summarised in the following sections.

3.1 The qualities approach - who leaders are

The idea that leaders are born, not made, has given rise to many studies of the personal qualities and character of leaders. They seek to identify those characteristics which make leaders special or powerful and which set them apart from others. The kinds of traits that have been considered include physical characteristics such as height, weight, physique, age and energy level; individual abilities such as intelligence, fluency of speech, knowledge and expertise; and aspects of personality such as dominance, self-confidence, emotional resilience and interpersonal sensitivity. Although some traits, such as assertiveness, decisiveness, dependability, persistence, self-confidence and creativity, and some skills - verbal fluency, persuasiveness - appear to be characteristic of successful leaders, possession of the traits does not guarantee success nor their absence proscribe it. At best all that can be said is that possession of certain traits may be a necessary, but not a sufficient condition for leadership.

In professional arenas, professional and technical competence is often a prerequisite for assuring credibility among colleagues and with clients. It is not, however, essential to be the top performer or international expert; more a matter of being a competent and probably above average practitioner. In addition, intellectual and conceptual abilities, interpersonal skills, communication, negotiation, courage and risk-taking, and the ability to process large amounts and types of information have also been found to be important qualities

3.2 Behavioural theories - what leaders do

Perhaps because no one could isolate a single list of leadership qualities that applied in all cases, attention turned to the behaviour and style of leaders. This approach to leadership tapped a rich vein and has left us with some abiding insights into its practice.

One major group of researchers in the USA in the 1940s identified two important dimensions which they labelled: *'initiating structure'* and *'consideration'.* Another group concentrated on differences between formal leadership exercised by those in designated positions of authority and informal leadership exercised in peer-groups or other circumstances. Respectively, they noted the importance of 'goal emphasis' on the one hand and 'mutual support' on the other. Out of these studies, four dimensions of leadership behaviour have emerged and endured:

- ***goal emphasis***: stimulating commitment to the achievement of goals, including high levels of performance

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- ***work facilitation***: providing the technical and organisational means for accomplishing goals
- ***support:*** behaviour that enhances a sense of worth in others, and
- ***interaction-facilitation***: the building of mutually satisfying group relationships.

In the UK, these ideas were taken up by John Adair and developed into his well-known action-centred approach to leadership. Adair suggested that in organisations, as in other groups where people worked together in close proximity, three sets of needs had to be satisfied: the need to achieve a task, the need to be recognised and dealt with as an individual and the need to be held together as a group. The prime function of leadership was to pay attention to these three sets of needs. Successful leaders were those who maintained a dynamic and creative balance between the three.

Other researchers developed these behavioural building blocks further by examining the way in which individual leaders carried out the functions described above. Their emphasis on leadership style, in a sense, married the qualities and behavioural approaches together. Out of this, different models of leadership emerged, for example, Blake and Mouton's Managerial Grid on which leadership style could be plotted along two dimensions: concern for task and concern for people, or Likert's six systems of management (or styles) which included: 'exploitative-authoritative', 'benevolent-authoritative', 'consultative', 'participative', 'permissive' and 'collective' approaches. Out of these early perspectives on leadership behaviour and style, a range of diagnostic tools have been created to assist leaders and potential leaders in identifying their preferred styles and in developing alternative approaches to leadership.

For the partner in a small practice the problem with such models is making sense of and using one. There are a myriad of ‘psychological profiles’ on the market aimed at helping you assess your own, and colleagues preferred styles of working and behaving. There is no hard evidence to support the view that any single model has proved more successful than any other.

It is worth a leader, or would be leader, being aware of his or her own preferred ‘styles’ and ‘biases’ and how these might interact with those of colleagues, staff and clients. If not, the danger is simply collecting around you a group of like-minded and like thinking individuals, or of alienating existing clients. If a professional management team does decide to pursue such an approach as part of its team building it is worth ensuring that everyone involved participates in the same process.

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3.3 Contingency approaches - it all depend's

A significant development from the study of leadership style was the recognition that style, behaviour, and even qualities, differed according to context and circumstances. Most people would acknowledge that the style of national leadership differs in wartime from peacetime or that a more authoritarian style is necessary in an emergency such as a fire or car accident than in day-to-day routines. Contingency approaches to leadership sought to identify what kind of 'contingencies' led to shifts in leadership in order to develop more sophisticated and targeted approaches.

Different researchers concentrated on different variables. Some of the most important include:

- The ***quality of relationships*** within a group: How good are they? Is there an appropriate balance between harmony and creative conflict?
- The ***nature of the task***, particularly its degree of structure: How much ambiguity is there? or How many dilemmas need to be resolved? Is the task routine and predictable or is it messy and unclear ?
- The ***characteristics of group members*** in terms of abilities, qualities and motivation: How willing and able are staff? What roles do they take on in groups? What motivates them at work or more broadly?
- The ***position of the leader***, particularly in relation to power: How was the leader selected? What is the structure of group roles and tasks? What are the expectations of clients, staff, colleagues about the leadership role?
- ***Time***: How urgent is the task? At what stage of development is the organisation?
- The ***decision making process***: What is the balance of control over decisions between the leader and others, e.g. colleagues, clients? How significant is the decision at this point?
- ***Culture:*** how do prevailing habits, beliefs and attitudes affect leadership, either locally within organisations, or across organisations and countries?

Above all deciding on how to play things will be heavily dominated by where the power lies.

3.4 Power and influence - how to make things happen

Interest in the power of leaders to influence others has a long history as many political and military biographies attest. Since leadership is often defined as a process of social influence which guides people towards a goal, the way in which influence is exerted has been of considerable interest to researchers. Generally, a distinction is made between 'power' which is described as the ability to give orders enforced by sanctions, punishment and control of rewards, 'influence' which is seen as the ability to change the actions of others through persuasion, reasoned argument or by appeals to emotions other than greed or fear, and 'authority' which is a means of legitimating the use of particular powers and influence.

An important backdrop to notions of power and influence involves analysing the sources of power upon which authority and influence rest. These include:

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- role and position
- the ability to offer financial rewards
- coercive power through threat of punishments
- credibility through knowledge and expertise
- personality and interpersonal skills
- political visibility
- social approval
- psychological support
- acquisition and ability to provide resources
- access to information and client-base and reputation

Analysis of these different power bases drew attention to the ways in which they were used by leaders and those with whom they interacted to enable goals to be achieved, the group to cohere, or clients to be satisfied with the products and services delivered. Two contrasting approaches were recognised :

3.4.1 Transactional Leadership

Transactional leadership assumes that both leaders and followers have access to sources of power and influence and that both need each other in different ways. The leadership process therefore involves a social transaction, or implicit negotiation, in which followers trade certain freedoms (such as individual action and decision-taking) in return for the benefits of group membership and effective leadership. Leaders can provide psychological support, task structuring, access to resources, including contacts and information, political visibility and representation of interests in return for the income generated by motivated individuals and groups.

3.4.2 Transformational Leadership,

On the other hand, places more power and influence in the hands of the leader who is viewed as capable of producing higher order change in both individuals and organisations. Transformational leadership goes beyond meeting individuals' needs for security or recognition towards engaging their motivation, energy and drive through a sense of worth, high purpose or moral value. Transformational leadership can have significant moral connotations when linked to a cause such as liberty, justice or equality or can be associated with inspirational or innovative ideas and activities. Particular strategies have been linked with transformational leadership, for example:

- Promoting attention through ***vision*** (having a clear agenda and being oriented towards results)
- Making sense of, and communicating a clear view of the world through the use of metaphors, images and models to ***provide explanations and convey meaning,***

- Gaining trust by displaying ***accountability***, predictability, constancy and reliability, and

- Gaining recognition or attention through ***positive self-regard*** (maximising strengths and minimising weaknesses).

While transactional leadership is more common in professional environments, both because of the nature of the professional tasks and the nature of the individuals, transformational leadership may be needed when either a profession or an organisation is engaged in significant change. The problem with transformational leaders is that they tend not to know when to stop. Many a transformational leader has overstayed her [or his] welcome sometimes contributing to more problems than they solved.

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3.5 Symbolism and Culture - 'managing meaning'

Developing out of studies of leadership style, behaviour and influence in different settings and circumstances comes the idea that leadership is part of the belief systems which create frameworks and meanings for our working lives. Firms have been compared to tribes or nations drawn together by their particular rituals, myths, rites of passage and hierarchies.

Join The Club

What have your local golf club and a professional service firm got in common?

Part of the answer lies in membership. Anyone joining any organisation has one or more contracts, agreed in the rituals of joining. These can be formal, as with the application, subscription and constitution of the golf club or the selection process and contract of employment signed with the firm. There will also exist an unwritten, informal, implicit psychological contract. Such an agreement is always formed between individuals and any organisation to which they belong. Unlike a legal contract the 'contract of relationship' is dynamic. It is a 'living' agreement; one that is continually being renegotiated, sometimes in very subtle and sometimes in very obvious ways. It produces, or defines, sets of expectations and contributions.

One does not seek, and one is unlikely to be granted, membership of the golf club without at least a passing interest in the game of golf and a level of skill commensurate with the expectations of the particular club. With some that level of skill might be a single figure handicap. With others it suffices to demonstrate to the club professional that you can hit the ball. You receive in return some implied promises concerning the standards of play and social behaviour shown by other members. You may have expectations concerning opportunities for social or commercial networking. You are prepared, in return, to fit in with the codes and conventions of the particular club.

The recruitment process is not that different. Those who do not strike a prospective employer as likely to fit in are unlikely to be employed, nor are firms likely to receive applications from those who have no interest or expectation of fitting in. Research shows that such decisions are typically taken in the first 30 seconds of a selection interview. In some firms the formal contract may then be no more than a brief and standard letter of agreement. The informal contract reigns supreme. It defines the standards of membership, of the firm as much as the club, and of particular groupings within either. The codes of behaviour for partners may differ to those for the back office. Both are an expression of the 'rituals' of the profession and the practice.

Investigating the rituals and 'unwritten rules' are important aspects of a leaders role. For example, it also throws new light on leadership. For example, it focuses attention on the ways in which leaders create their own myth, or how others create a myth about their achievements (or lack of them).

The ways in which communication takes place in the office, the language that is used, the layout of office space, the marketing messages, the social interactions of the firm and the way promotions are handled and status granted enable, and constrain, the firm's

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performance. They provide not only important clues about the organisation's values and culture, but also highlight the ways in which leadership is exercised. Through acting as an 'organisational anthropologist', leaders can learn to understand and use a range of cultural and symbolic tools to extend their influence and effectiveness. But watch out. Anthropologists learnt to study tribal cultures so as to preserve them. The leader may have to stand back from the culture so as to change it.

Paying attention to symbolism and culture can provide leaders with other useful tips such as:

- *'Walking the talk'* - making sure the message and the medium are consistent.
- '*Encouraging the heart'* - recognising effort and achievement by celebrating and expressing gratitude.
- *'Modelling the way'* - setting an example.
- *'Planning small wins'* - demonstrate success in stages.
- *'Learn the unwritten rules'* - tap into the real organisational blocks.

3.6 Cognitive theories

Other recent research on leadership, building on developments in psychology and artificial intelligence, has concentrated on 'the mind' of leaders and followers. This has led in many directions including, how leaders and followers construe reality and the influence of such mental pictures on assumptions and expectations of how things happen. A metaphor may help. Imagine a landscape, eroded over time to provide streams, rivulets, and rivers interspersed between higher plateaux. If the virgin landscape starts relatively flat, then as rain falls so it tends to find the paths of least resistance. Over time accumulations of rainfall carve out stream and river beds and settle into pools and lakes. Any new rainfall will no longer find its own way but will rather take, and re-enforce, a pre-existing pattern. Though the falling rain may be evenly distributed across the landscape, in its collection and flow across the land it will tend towards a predetermined route, one taken by previous rainfalls.

Just as the rainfall follows established routes so perception follows established ways of 'seeing'. Technically, even if the light sources which perturb the back of our retinas, or acoustic vibrations our eardrums, are identical, what is noticed from all that could be seen or heard depends on the perceptual lens through which we view the world. The optimist's half-full glass is the pessimists half-empty one! What is there is what we have been 'trained' [or conditioned, or have learnt] to see. Our experience means that we will not see certain other things which do not fit with our personal 'meaning-set'. We may discard, indeed we can literally be blind to, anomalies that do not fit.

Exploring the analogy further we could say that a new idea is like the single raindrop. It falls with others upon a pre-formed perceptual landscape. Isolated thoughts gather together in a string - which we might compare to a few drops congregating together in a splash of water. With sufficient mass the splash of water starts to flow into streams and rivers which lead to our concept pools and theory lakes. Thinking, seeing, and behaving tend to follow pre-existing patterns

Cognitive theories have thrown light on the role of leaders in creating, and redirecting such patterns. They highlight the interrelationships between ideas, assumptions and expectations and the ways in which organisations are structured and roles carried out. They have also focused attention on the need for 'cognitive complexity' as an aspect of effective leadership in the modern world. This intellectual skill involves being able to understand situations through different 'lenses', to be able to generate alternative scenarios for action, and to recognise the interrelationships between different systems and dimensions - of funding, client-base, organisational structure, marketing strategy, employee motivation, production and service delivery etc.

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3.7 Integrating Theory with Practice

All of these theories provide useful frameworks for thinking about leadership. Each provides a particular insight into a complex subject. Theories do, however, need to be implemented. Good inter-personal skills are not enough for the leader in a professional service firm. Conceptual thinking skills; seeing what needs to be done, explaining it and exciting others to want to do it is also required. The following section therefore considers, at a more practical level what you as leader need to do to influence individual professionals. ***How do you herd cats in the least painful manner?***

4. How to Herd Cats

4.1 Know Your Cats

The wise leader knows her cats. If all professionals were passive and willing sheep, or dogs who could be trained to perform tricks for a devoted Partner life would be easy. But consider some of the characters in the feline orchestra. How do you engage the following as opportunities rather than problems? The challenge in each case is to extract and enable the contribution they have to make. The danger is that you try and dramatically change their behaviour. Teaching an old cat (or for that matter a young kitten) to perform new tricks can be very difficult. Playing to their strengths might be a better ploy.

To help you identify your 'cats' and their strengths (and limitations), we have created nine hypothetical types of cat you might encounter in your practice. Some of the nine lives your cat might pass through include;

Solo cat - *'The loner who walks by himself'*
Top cat - *'The entrepreneur who wants to drive every deal'*
Aristo cat - *'The traditionalist: for whom the old professional ways are not only still best but still the only way'.*
Plain old puss - *'Reliable and friendly: but passed over for promotion and lacking apparent motivation to change his ways'*
Grand old cat - *'Great in his day but living on the memory and reputation of past glories'*
No 10's cat - *'The consummate politician, usually on the look out for No 1'*
The cat who 'always lands on his feet' - *difficult to pin down and make accountable, and*
The cat with attitude - *'Has an opinion on everything and is always right - in his eyes anyway'*

'Solo cat'
Many professionals, especially in highly specialised or technological areas, are prone to be solo workers - getting on with the job their way. They work for the stimulation of using and developing their professional skills and relish the time to develop their new ideas, their way. It is an easy temptation to ask them to be involved in wider departmental activities; perhaps leading some specialist group or committee but it rarely pays off. One needs to give the solo cat a clear idea of what is wanted and clear boundaries beyond which she cannot stray. Within these more is gained by encouraging her to develop and mentor others than by expecting her to conform to a collective way of doing things.

'Top cat'
Get some people engaged with a new idea and they will be off developing it in directions you never thought off. Ask them to work with someone else's idea and it's a different story. The entrepreneur loves the thrill of the new deal and the sense that they are taking

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a risk. The challenge may be to stop them from going so far, so fast, that they fail to realise how many people are not keeping up.

These are the people who are motivated by status symbols and titles. They respond to accountability and responsibility but may need that accountability clearly defined before they go too far.

'Aristocat'
'That's not how we did it in my day' 'Not a professional job' 'Standards of professional excellence are falling'. The traditionalist, or professional purist, poses one of the greatest leadership dilemmas. He may be a custodian of many of the firms valued skills but time is passing him by and clients fade away.

New incentives, new responsibilities can help re-motivate such a person but the leader frequently has to spend time in one-on-one coaching, inviting and challenging the aristocat to see the world differently. You cannot change them. You can only encourage them to change themselves. Sometimes a complete shift to a different environment helps.

'Plain old puss'
The professional who has let time pass him by, and is either content to lie by the fire, or is disillusioned and withdrawn needs to feel valued if they are to deliver value. Unfortunately they may have risen to their level of incompetence then stopped. Honesty is the only answer. If possible play to their strengths and encourage them to work in a different way, perhaps as (again mixing metaphors) wise old owls alongside a rising young star. If they are also honest it is at least possible.

'The Grand Old Cat'
Whereas a plain old puss may find it a relief to know their limits, a star from another era living on past glories can be a greater challenge. If you need them to remain motivated they tend to require ever-greater doses of ego massaging and peer recognition. Their great value is in the 'chair of our executive committee' role. Let them deal with those often value-detracting tasks that other departments, or other organisations throw at you. No regulatory authority or local council ever gets tired of being told that 'the chair of our executive committee' takes care of that. It may even enhance the firms status whilst leaving you time to lead and stopping the old cat seeking his status at your expense. If that doesn't work find a way to give them a sufficiently rude shock that a dose of reality is injected.

'The Number 10 Cat'
Political animals just love networking and intriguing, sometimes for their own imagined gain and sometimes for the sheer pleasure of it. You want them doing it where it earns the firm a reputation with your clients rather than inside. Create the opportunity for them to play games and use their real skills where it won't do any real damage. Feed their fantasy if you have to. If it gets serious you can help them invent a fictitious plot whereby whatever you don't actually want them to do is impossible after all.

The cat who 'always lands on his feet'
Whilst all cats are generally sure footed some have the uncanny knack of avoiding any sense of failure and always land on their feet. These are the 'teflon types', nothing sticks, difficult to pin down and make accountable when things go wrong. Bide your time. You'll need to be patient and painstaking if you are to play on their pitch. Use their knowledge of systems and rules to your benefit. They know all the loopholes and dodges, involve them in reviewing procedures and contracts. Poachers turned gamekeepers can be useful allies.

'The cat with attitude'
Some people have a compulsion to look good and be right, to the point of being righteous. When you want someone to stone wall in the firms interest's outside it is

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wonderful. When you want the orchestra to play to a different tune it is a pain. Feed their obsession when it doesn't matter and there is more chance they will listen to you when it does.

At different times you want all these people in your team. Many research projects into team performance have established that great teams succeed in using and respecting different styles of working at different stages of the task in hand. There are any number of psychometric profiles available from quick self-assessments to expensive computer generated profiles. None has established an overarching reputation, despite the claims of their advocates to the contrary. What many of them can do is to give the leader an insight into different personalities and styles of operating. A team that uses one such tool together can get a collective insight into each others personality and the styles of communication that are likely to work best for a given individual and situation.

4.2 Styles of Herding

There are many styles of developing and leading your practice. Staying with the theme of cats we can think of different ways people have evolved for controlling the behaviour of their animals.

One is chance: ***random natural selection***. Animals that do not change become extinct when the environment changes (remember the dinosaur). The current fashion for helping organisations change endorses the view that leaders do not wish their companies to suffer the same fate.

The second is ***conditioning***. We have been doing this to animals for thousands of years, rewarding the behaviour we wish to encourage and punishing that which we do not want. We learnt to herd sheep and more recently to raise hens in batteries so as to optimise - or at least maximise - output. No one ever managed to do it to cats. However, much classical management theory and even some modern ideas, operate on the same underlying principle; break a task down into its components and condition a workforce to perform them. It is a mode of leadership that simply does not work when you require the people being led to use their initiative.

The third is ***training***. Training animals extends conditioning to a wider repertoire of responses to a range of signals or instructions. Repeat the same task enough times and you can train a rat to run round a maze, or at least a young dog to perform new tricks - but the dog is still the same dog. Unfortunately many of our prescriptions for bringing about more fundamental change through training are about as effective. Instruct the workforce that this is how it is done, with implied reward for compliance and penalty for failure and - so the training paradigm has it - you have a world-beating organisation. Countless thousands of failed initiatives on standards, and quality, and benchmarking later we know that too much training does not work. At worst it is has not escaped the Taylorist paradigm. At best it leaves little room for people to discover and own their personal solutions; little room, in a word, for learning and creativity. ***Who-ever heard of training a cat?***

The fourth is ***bribery***. Kit-e-kat will keep the cat complacent, especially if it has also had a small operation. The result is a cat who is not necessarily good at catching mice and risks being a drain on your resources.

The fifth is ***selective breeding***. The agricultural revolution happened when plant and animal breeders learnt to breed better stocks and cat fanciers have followed suit. Selective breeding can produce far more elegant cats, given time. It is however susceptible to the risk of genetic leakage whenever the pedigree stock is interfered with. It also leads to cats that cannot survive in an unprotected environment. The organisational equivalent of selective breeding is probably recruitment. Hire only those

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who display precisely the behaviour you want and do not use too much initiative. Create a totally compliant and dependent workforce: if you think it will be a recipe for success in a professional service business

The last approach to changing organisms is ***genetic engineering***, still in its infancy but capable - if we chose - of far reaching changes, and harbouring far-reaching dangers. In the world of the organisations we genetically engineer a company when we modify the unwritten rules, the thinking habits and traditions, the way things are done round here. Changing the rules allows and indeed forces different behaviour to evolve. It creates climates and situations in which initiative, or a real feeling for the client, or teamwork, is encouraged. Preventing established ways of thinking from dominating the firm stops the organisation becoming stuck, like the unsuccessful animal, in its own traditions.

Cats want to perform and preen themselves. Given the right encouragement they are natural hunters and chasers after new opportunities. They are curious and even creative. The challenge for the leader is to set a score that the others want to play by.

4.3 Know where you want to go

There is a well validated story of a group of soldiers lost on an exercise in the Alps. They wandered aimlessly until one produced a map and said 'Let's go'. They marched to safety and only then discovered that the map was of the Pyrenees. Leaders have the knack of setting direction, whether by marching out in front and inspiring others to follow, or by subtle influence. Either the leader knows where he or she wants to go, or they know the direction, or they at least know that they do not want to stay where they are.

If you know where you are going good. If you don't make the journey sound exciting - it is up to you to enrol people and take them with you.

Consider a supertanker. Who among those responsible for the ship is the leader. Most would say the Captain, some the Navigation Officer or even the Helmsman. Yet on a modern, ocean going ship the navigator is a computer linked to the Global Positioning Satellite (GPS) system. The Captain steers the ship in and out of crowded ports, and in between times, ensures that someone watches out for stray yachtsmen, flags of convenience freighters, and other occasional perils that would otherwise ruin a peaceful and straightforward voyage. There have been cases reported of dogs being trained to fulfil the lookout role and bark if the radar bleeps.

Management might be easier, if organisations were as predictable as supertankers and if their environment and strategy could be reduced to a course on a chart. They are not and it can't. The leader of a professional services firm in today's turbulent environments has more in common with the navigators of a by gone era such as Vasco De Gama, Henry Cabot, Christopher Columbus, Francis Drake, or even James Cook. The renaissance navigators were simultaneously custodians of new knowledge and skills, guardians of someone else's investment and leaders of voyages of discovery; voyages into unknown potential during which the craft and the crew had to be re-engineered as one went along. They also possessed, in the words of one modern yachtsman a sense of their relationship to their surroundings, an appreciation of the sea, that we can never know.

The early navigators were businessmen. Their voyages were funded, either by royal sponsors, or by partnerships of merchant venturers: indeed such partnerships were the beginning of the limited company that we know today. They were also leaders, by virtue of skill and of character. They were leaders, not through background but through skill and knowledge. Most did not come not from the ruling elites of their time. They were the visionaries who created and led new forms of enterprise, making profit by knowing where they were whilst they explored uncharted waters.

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But they had a relatively uneducated bunch of seamen to lead. The modern professional finds him / herself leading a group, all of whom are likely to think they have at least as good an idea of where they want to go as does the navigator or Captain. ***So how do you get the orchestra playing to your tune?***

4.4 Conducting Your Feline Orchestra

(a) Creating context - Ambience and acoustics

The wise conductor, if given a choice, starts with the environment and atmosphere in which the orchestra will play. Fix that and you have predisposed the orchestra, and the audience, to a different result. Put the same 4 musicians in a pub playing to a jam session and in a stately garden playing to the great and good and they will sound and play differently.

It is sometimes almost too easy. The manager / leader has so many opportunities to create a different physical environment that they have the odds stacked, almost, in their favour - yet most of the time they ignore them. Physical space is divided out according to lines and levels on the organisation chart then people wonder why the levels and lines do not communicate.

Human beings are adaptable creatures. We did not get where we are by being anything but. Set the environment and most people either respond or seek something different within a very short order of time.

But of course it is not just the physical environment. The values and habits the leader projects. The openness and honesty, or otherwise, the integrity, the formality or informality, the things that it is permissible to discuss openly and the conversations that people keep for the bar with their trusted friends are all part of creating the ambience.

(b) Role playing v improvisation

Everyone's classic image of the well organised orchestra has the composer writing the score, the conductor interpreting and the orchestra playing when the baton moves. Most managers dream of achieving such synchronisation. But the creative professionals may have more in common with the jazz group improvising in a jam session, and responding to the mood of each other and their audience. What enables superlative improvisation?

Part of it is relationship and understanding: the shared sense of mutual trust and knowledge built up ‘off-line’ in moments that are not critical. Part of it is practice. In no field of human endeavour other than business do people expect outstanding results from teams that have not practised together. Part of it is the underlying score.

It is far easier for the orchestra to arrive at a creative and original interpretation of a classic score than to compose the whole symphony from scratch. Choosing the score is part of the leaders job; setting the systems and procedures, the corporate ground rules, by which the team will operate.

(c) The importance of rhythm

The rhythm for the ordinary orchestra is easy. It is there in the score, or it is set by the drummer who dictates the time. The conductor of the feline orchestra has to set the pace, the beat, by which the cats move and play.

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Fortunately it is not as difficult as it sounds. Create a beat and folk will join in. What is the beat of the firm? In the main it is the conversations that go on, the way people talk about the company and what it is up to. Ring up your office sometime when you are away. Listen like a visitor or a new client. Does the message come across with conviction. Are you in the sort of place you would actually want to spend money with? Another good test is just to ask professionals how much fun they are having. Its not foolproof - some don't think of work and fun as related, but for many it is as good a quick test as any. Then there are the key words of the organisation. How much 'yes but" goes on? Do conversations go around in circles with everyone discussing how important it is to get started then relapsing into another discussion of all the things that happen until they can. Certain professions in particular love drowning in detail.

How well do you know what gets people in your organisation out of bed in the morning. What makes them want to come to work, or do they have to, leaving their enthusiasm and commitment for the distractions we call leisure? In a firm that is led and not just managed it is unlikely that people will feel obliged to leave their individuality at the door as they check in. The leader creates a sense of enthusiasm and a shared sense of being for each other.

One reason the partnership form of organisation has survived in professional firms is that it actually encourages a sense of team based performance. Partners, by definition, have a stake in each other's success. The danger is that, in the interests of efficiency, that stake is lost, if not between partners then lower down the organisation. Management by objectives, and the associated imposition of pay for individual performance and rigid appraisal systems, actually do not work well in many situations where the essence of success is the interdependent communication between different professionals. It can actually set up barriers, where in extreme cases, individuals spend more time competing with each other than with the outside world. Ask some of your key players who their competition is? Then ask them whether the first name that came to mind was inside the firm [or division if you are that large] or outside.

Every organisation has its Unwritten Rules, the underlying rhythm and ways of doing things that are followed without question. If they didn't nothing would ever get done. Like motorway speed limits [exceed by 10%] or some marital partnerships [where the Unwritten Rule may be don't get caught] your firm will have Unwritten Rules which may or may not encourage the kind of behaviour you want to see to achieve your business objectives. Very often the rule is 'don't be too different'; good for harmony but sometimes fatal for originality. The Cheetah enjoys a reputation as the sleekest and fastest cat of all. In fact it is on an evolutionary dead end possessed of less capacity to adapt, less genetic diversity, than any other members of the cat family. For the professional orchestra the equivalent capacity is the ability to think differently, and play to a different rhythm when the need arises.

5. Conclusions

If you had not already recognised it, being successful in the role of leader in a professional service organisation can be a challenging activity. To achieve success requires a mixture of effort and luck - although as in so many aspects of human endeavour, the more you practise the luckier you get. Above all it requires a wish to succeed, a wish to become respected by your peers (and your clients) - which might be different than receiving credit for getting things done.

The paper has provided a brief overview of how professional service firms and professionals differ from more conventional hierarchical structures - fail to recognise these differences and you will be unlikely to succeed. Second, recognise that leadership is largely a skill, an activity which can improve through practise and reflection. It is not some innate characteristic which only a few individuals possess. The skills required are

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partly an understanding of what makes each team member tick, what motivates them and how you can create the conditions (physical and mental) where each person can utilise their talents to maximum effect. ***For example, does the physical environment of your office encourage the style of behaviour you wish to encourage?***

The cat and orchestral metaphors have been used to explore the particular features of the professional and professional organisations. Neither metaphor can capture all of the characteristics and complexity of the individuals or the process. On the other hand both can provide insights into a phenomena which can be very difficult to describe. ***Does your culture and personal style give your cats the right amount of freedom within which to operate?***

The need for leadership is generally recognised by most professionals. The challenge for the future is to create a form of leadership which has more to do with 'getting people to follow you' rather than according to the somewhat dated, heroic, military images, which have so often been used to describe leadership in the past.

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